Things to Do in Chattanooga, TN

Original Author: Jack Byram

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Geo coverage: Chattanooga, TN and surrounding area

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This page is an index of every interactive guide on Things Happening for Chattanooga. Each guide covers a specific category with filterable listings, description boxes, and direct links to maps.

Chattanooga has more outdoor range than most mid-size cities. The Tennessee River runs through the center of downtown. Lookout Mountain, Signal Mountain, and the Tennessee River Gorge are all within 30 minutes. That geography shows up across almost every guide here.

The city breaks into a few distinct areas. Downtown and Bluff View are on the south bank of the river. The North Shore sits across the Walnut Street Bridge. St. Elmo and the Southside are south of downtown. Lookout Mountain rises just to the south and is covered in its own guides.

Each guide is interactive and filterable. You can narrow by neighborhood, type, price range, or specific activity. Most guides cover between 13 and 74 locations. Description boxes appear for each filter with context on what to expect. Links to each guide are in both the text and the grid cards at the end of each section.

For visitors planning a full weekend, the weekend hosting guide builds a two-day itinerary around the Choo Choo district. If a guide is missing something or has outdated information, send an email.

Outdoors & Adventures

Chattanooga sits at the foot of the Appalachians with the Tennessee River running through it. That geography puts hiking, paddling, mountain biking, and caving within a short drive. The Chattanooga outdoor adventures guide covers 74 activities with filters for type, location, and difficulty.

Hiking. Lookout Mountain has more than a dozen routes. The Glen Falls trail is one mile to a waterfall. The Guild Hardy Loop climbs 1,700 feet to the summit. Signal Mountain has the Rainbow Lake to Edwards Point loop with gorge views. Prentice Cooper State Forest has two hard routes, Pot Point and Mullens Cove, both over nine miles. Stringers Ridge is inside the city with two accessible loops under four miles each.

Paddling and biking. At dusk, around 100,000 bats leave a riverside cave. The bat cave kayak trip puts you on the water to watch it happen. The Tennessee River Blueway is a 45-mile flatwater route. For mountain biking, Raccoon Mountain has an 11-mile technical loop. Enterprise South Nature Park has beginner trails that add up to an 8-mile ride. The River to

Clouds route connects Cloudland Canyon to Lookout Mountain to downtown on 34 miles.

Caving and wildlife. Raccoon Mountain Caverns has a guided walking tour and a wild cave crawl. Ruby Falls on Lookout Mountain is a 145-foot underground waterfall. Reflection Riding Arboretum has 300 acres of trails and guided tours with red wolves and birds of prey. See the full list of Chattanooga outdoor activities for every route, launch point, and seasonal note.

The Chattanooga guided tours guide covers city history, ghost, kayak, cave, and hiking tours. Prices run from $25 to $80 per person.

City and history. Chattanooga Trolley Tours runs four options: a city overview, a true crime and haunted history tour, a combined trolley and historic train ride, and a museum add-on with vintage cars. Tours run 60 to 240 minutes. Chattanooga Ducks puts you in a restored WWII amphibious vehicle, drives through downtown, then goes straight into the Tennessee River. Chattanooga Rydables runs motorized scooter groups across the Walnut Street Bridge and through downtown. Routes run one hour or 90 minutes.

Outdoor and adventure tours. The bat cave sunset kayak is a 3-mile guided paddle at dusk. Around 100,000 bats leave a riverside cave while you're on the water. It runs March through October and needs no prior kayaking experience. Experience Chattanooga runs private guided hikes with Tennessee River gorge views. One version adds an alpaca farm stop. Chickamauga Battlefield has ranger-led tours on weekends and a self-guided NPS app tour across eight points of interest.

Outdoor Adventures

74 hikes, trails, paddling spots, and outdoor activities. Filterable by type, location, and difficulty.

Cloudland Canyon State Park

Cloudland Canyon hiking, waterfalls, caves, and mountain biking. About one hour from Chattanooga.

Guided Tours

City history, ghost, kayak, cave, and hiking tours. Prices run $25–$80 per person.

Food & Drink

The independent coffee scene here covers most neighborhoods. The Chattanooga coffee shops guide covers 28 spots with filters for neighborhood, wifi, and vibe. Goodman Coffee Roasters is on Market Street downtown. Rembrandt's in Bluff View roasts its own beans and sits above the river. The North Shore has Stone Cup and a Mean Mug location with a scratch kitchen. Velo Coffee Roasters on the Southside shares a space with a bike shop. Sleepyhead on Broad Street does vegan pastries. Milk and Honey on North Market adds gelato and weekend brunch.

Breweries and wineries. Chattanooga has 20 craft producers in and around the city. Chattanooga Brewing Co sits downtown with a wide range of styles. Hutton and Smith and Oddstory are both on the Southside. Wanderlinger has a beer garden with enough space to settle in. The Chattanooga Whiskey Experimental Distillery runs small-batch releases and tours. North Georgia wineries are within an hour's drive. Cartecay Vineyards and Engelheim Vineyards both have tasting rooms. See the full Chattanooga breweries and wineries guide for all 20 locations.

Restaurants with a view. The Tennessee River and the ridgelines around it put some decent views within reach of most meals. The Boathouse sits at water level on the riverfront. Whitebird at The Edwin looks out over the Walnut Street Bridge. Top of the Rock in Jasper is 30 minutes out and sits on a mountain summit. River Gorge Ranch overlooks the Tennessee River Gorge. Canyon Grill is on the Lookout Mountain ridgeline. The restaurants with a view guide covers all 13 spots with notes on what to order and when to go.

Sweet treats. The Chattanooga confections guide covers bakeries, chocolate shops, and dessert spots across the city. Worth adding to any neighborhood itinerary.

Coffee Shops

28 coffee shops across Chattanooga. Filter by neighborhood, wifi, or vibe.

Breweries & Wineries

20 breweries, wineries, and cideries in and around Chattanooga.

Restaurants with a View

13 spots with riverfront, rooftop, or mountain views.

Sweet Treats

Bakeries, chocolate shops, and dessert spots around the city.

Arts, Music & Sports

Bessie Smith grew up in Chattanooga. She went on to become one of the most recorded blues artists of the 1930s. Kane Brown, Lauren Alaina, and Usher also have Chattanooga roots. The Chattanooga live music guide covers local bars, recurring events, larger venues, and festivals. The Woodshop in St. Elmo is a listening room that leans toward bluegrass and local artists. JJ's Bohemia has run as a neighborhood dive bar and live music spot since 2006. Larger shows go to The Signal, Barrelhouse Ballroom, and Songbirds. Riverfront Nights and Nightfall are the main recurring outdoor events. The IBMA Bluegrass Festival and Smart Music Fest anchor the fall calendar. See all venues in the live music guide.

Performing arts. The Tivoli Theatre on Broad Street reopens October 20, 2026 after a four-year, $75 million restoration. Billy Strings plays the first

shows back. Memorial Auditorium holds 3,866 and runs concerts, comedy, and community events. The Walker Theatre seats 851 with notably clear acoustics. Chattanooga Symphony & Opera plays film scores live to picture. They ran Star Wars in recent seasons. The performing arts guide covers Barking Legs Theater, Chattanooga Theatre Centre, Chattanooga Ballet, and The Comedy Catch. See the full Chattanooga performing arts guide for schedules and venue details.

Museums and exhibits. The Chattanooga exhibits guide covers 19 spots across art, history, science, and more. The Tennessee Aquarium sits on the riverfront with two buildings. River Journey covers freshwater ecosystems and Ocean Journey covers saltwater. There is an IMAX theater on site. The Hunter Museum of American Art sits on an 80-foot bluff above the river with nearly 3,000 works across three connected buildings. Creative Discovery Museum has programming built for kids. Sculpture Fields is 33 acres of rotating large-scale contemporary art, free and open any time. The Bessie Smith Cultural Center has rotating exhibits alongside a permanent history collection. The Tennessee Valley Railroad Museum runs heritage train rides, including the 65-minute Missionary Ridge Local through a pre-Civil War tunnel. The Chattanooga Zoo at Warner Park is two miles east of downtown and keeps red pandas in its Himalayan Passage exhibit, an easy stop for families. Chickamauga Battlefield is 15 minutes into Georgia and marks one of the Civil War's largest engagements. See every museum, admission price, and visiting tip in the full exhibits guide.

Live sports. The Chattanooga Lookouts play Double-A baseball at Erlanger Park, which opened in April 2026. The new ballpark sits in the South Broad District on the old U.S. Pipe foundry site and seats about 8,000. The historic Power House building forms the main entrance. UTC Mocs football runs August through November at Finley Stadium, which holds over 20,000. Chattanooga FC plays MLS Next Pro at Finley Stadium from March through October. Their local fan section, the Chattahooligans,

is vocal and worth sitting near. The live sports guide covers every team, stadium tips, and sports bars for watching games. See the full Chattanooga live sports guide for tickets and seating notes.

Live Music

Venues, bars, and theaters with regular live music. Covers every genre and price range.

Performing Arts

Theater, dance, and live performance venues including the Tivoli and Chattanooga Theatre Centre.

Exhibits & Museums

19 museums and exhibits: the Tennessee Aquarium, Hunter Museum, Creative Discovery Museum, and more.

Live Sports

Lookouts baseball, UTC Mocs, Chattanooga FC, and where to watch every game.

The Chattanooga events calendar is updated daily with live music, markets, festivals, and community events. Most events are free or under

$25. It covers what is happening in the next 30 days and runs separately from these guides.

Every guide on this page is updated as new spots open and listings change. If a listing is wrong, a spot has closed, or a guide is missing something, send an email. Feedback from readers has improved every guide on this list.

FAQ.

What are the best things to do in Chattanooga?

The Tennessee Aquarium sits on the riverfront with two buildings covering freshwater and saltwater ecosystems. Outdoor activities range from Lookout Mountain hikes to Tennessee River paddling and caving at Raccoon Mountain. Live music runs most nights at venues across multiple neighborhoods. The interactive guides on this page cover all categories with filters and direct links.

How many days do you need in Chattanooga?

Two to three days covers the main categories. Day one works well as a downtown day: Aquarium, Hunter Museum, Bluff View, and riverfront. Day two covers outdoor activities on Lookout or Signal Mountain, or a day trip to Cloudland Canyon. A third day handles live music, breweries, and neighborhoods like St. Elmo or the North Shore.

What is Chattanooga known for?

Chattanooga is known for the Tennessee Aquarium, outdoor recreation including Lookout Mountain and the Tennessee River Gorge, and its live music heritage. Bessie Smith, Kane Brown, and Lauren Alaina all grew up here. Chickamauga Battlefield, 15 minutes south, was one of the largest Civil War engagements.

What can you do in Chattanooga for free?

Sculpture Fields at Montague Park is free and open any time. The Riverwalk is a free multi-mile trail along the Tennessee River. Stringers Ridge Park has two loops inside the city. Chickamauga Battlefield Visitor Center is free as a National Park Service site. The UTC Observatory runs free Star Parties on most Sunday evenings during the school year.

Is Chattanooga good for outdoor activities?

The outdoor adventures guide covers 74 activities including hiking, mountain biking, kayaking, paddleboarding, caving, and wildlife tours. Lookout Mountain has over a dozen hiking routes. The Tennessee River Blueway is a 45-mile flatwater paddling route. Raccoon Mountain has both mountain biking trails and a wild cave crawl.

What are the best neighborhoods to explore in Chattanooga?

Downtown has the Aquarium, Hunter Museum, and most riverfront dining. The North Shore on Frazier Ave has independent restaurants, coffee shops, and Coolidge Park. St.

Elmo, at the foot of Lookout Mountain, has the Incline Railway terminal, coffee shops, and restaurants. The Southside has most of the craft breweries and many live music venues.

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